
10Xpress
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Editor's Note

Greetings!

We're thrilled to bring you the first issue of the third volume of 10Xpress, the August edition. We are excited to start the new academic year by sharing some fantastic articles that we think you'll love, written by our committed student writers at 10X. Additionally, like we do for every volume, we have a new design that we will be using for the third volume. Lastly, we have a brand new website, which includes past issues and highlights, along with current updates.

If you have any thoughts on this issue or suggestions for improvement, please share them through our website. We can use this feedback to improve the newspaper for future volumes.

Finally, good luck with the examinations coming up ahead.

Bharat Ambati
Editor-in-Chief

Tardigrade Protein shows promising results in reducing radiation damage

Siddharth Mitra, 12: A recent breakthrough in biomedical research has highlighted the remarkable potential of tardigrades, microscopic organisms famous for their resilience, to improve cancer care. Scientists at MIT, the University of Iowa, and Brigham and Women's Hospital have successfully demonstrated that a protein unique to tardigrades can significantly reduce radiation damage in mice.

The protein, known as Dsup (damage suppressor), was delivered into specific tissues of mice using messenger RNA (mRNA) packaged in nanoparticles. Following exposure to radiation at levels similar to those used in clinical treatments, the mice displayed up to a **50% reduction in DNA damage** compared to untreated control trials. Thus, the radiation represents an important step toward mitigating one of the greatest challenges of radiation therapy: protecting healthy tissue while effectively targeting tumours during radiation therapy.

Although radiation is a powerful tool in cancer therapy, its side effects on surrounding non-cancerous tissue and cells often limit its use, resulting in patients having to stick to chemotherapy, which is much slower. Painful conditions, such as mouth sores, can force patients to interrupt or discontinue radiation therapy altogether. Encouragingly, in this study, the protective effect of Dsup, produced by tardigrades, was confined to the injected tissue, which was healthy and non-cancerous in nature. In other words, the tumours received maximum radiation exposure for effective treatment, but surrounding healthy cells remained unaffected by this radiation.

The method of delivery also commands clinical commendation. By using mRNA, cells are instructed to only temporarily produce the protective protein, reducing long-term safety concerns.

Researchers are now working on creating genetically engineered tardigrades that produce more effective versions of Dsup that are less likely to provoke immune responses, which paves the way for imminent clinical applications.

Regardless of the benefits, additional studies are necessary before this approach can be put into human clinical trials. The applications of this are not only limited purely to cancer care but could also potentially be used to protect astronauts from cosmic radiation during space missions.

Page [3]: Science

- Tardigrade Protein shows promising results in reducing radiation damage
- The Great Microplastic Mystery What's Really in Our Water?

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]:Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Reviews

Page [25]: School

The Great Microplastic Mystery: What's Really in Our Water?

Avantika Singh, 10: Have you ever pondered what is actually in the rivers you swim in, the oceans you visit, or the water you drink? Litter is a well-known issue, but microplastics pose a new and more dangerous threat. For good reason, these microscopic plastic particles, tinier than a grain of rice, have been dubbed "The Great Microplastic Mystery" and are becoming an increasingly significant issue.

Plastic fragments smaller than five millimetres are known as microplastics. They originate from different places. Some, like the microbeads in some toothpastes and face washes, are made to be tiny. However, the majority of microplastics originate from bigger plastic objects. Consider a tyre on the road, a shopping bag in a landfill or a plastic bottle left in the sun. These bigger plastics decompose into ever-tinier fragments over time, eventually turning into microplastics.

Thousands of microscopic plastic fibres can enter our waterways from a single load of laundry containing synthetic clothing (such as fleece or polyester). Car tires release microplastic particles onto the road as they deteriorate; these particles end up in rivers and storm drains. Over time, plastic bags, containers, and bottles decompose. Once in our surroundings, these microscopic fragments can spread widely due to wind and water currents. These days, they are found in the highest mountains, the deepest oceans, and even the air we breathe.

What is the true impact? Scientists are still unsure. We are aware that these plastic particles are being mistaken for food by marine life, ranging from enormous whales to microscopic plankton. Starvation, digestive issues, and even death may result from this. The question becomes more complex, though: are we drinking them? Microplastics are discovered in beer, bottled water, and tap water.

Some scientists are worried about the possibility that these plastics could introduce dangerous chemicals into our bodies, even though the long-term health effects on humans are still being studied. Like microscopic sponges, microplastics absorb contaminants like industrial chemicals and pesticides. The entire food chain may be impacted by the toxic substances that an animal consumes along with the plastic.

Although microplastics are a global issue, we must work together to address the problem. By making small changes in our daily routines, we can help preserve our planet and protect its water resources for future generations.

Page [3]: Science

- Tardigrade Protein shows promising results in reducing radiation damage
- The Great Microplastic Mystery What's Really in Our Water?

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]:Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Reviews

Page [25]: School

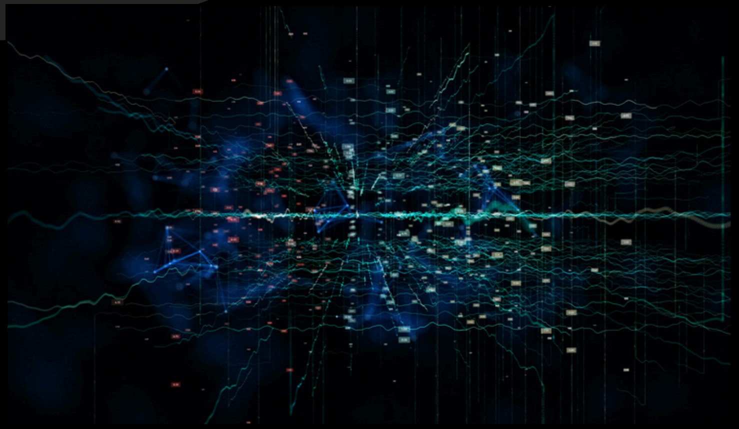
Numerical Simulations Unlock Secrets of the Qiantang River's "Matrix Tide"

Neil Daga, 12: The Qiantang River in eastern China is home to the world's largest tidal bore, a surge that can rise to nine meters and rush upstream at a speed of 40 kmph. This natural spectacle is both awe-inspiring and hazardous, capable of overturning boats and damaging riverfront infrastructure. Consequently, the locals named it "Silver Dragon" as a result of its characteristics. Among its most perplexing displays is the "matrix tide," a grid-like wave pattern formed when two undular bores collide: an event that has proven difficult to model mathematically.

For decades, scientists have struggled to understand the physics of such two-dimensional wave interactions. While one-dimensional tidal bore models have been studied since the mid-20th century, the complex equations governing multi-directional wave collisions were too computationally intensive. Recently, a research team from the University at Buffalo and the University of Colorado Boulder achieved a breakthrough by harnessing the power of high-performance supercomputing. Using Graphical Processing Units (GPUs) at UB's Centre for Computational Research, they solved the governing equations and successfully simulated the collision of two undular bores, reproducing the iconic "matrix tide."

Their models rely on advanced numerical techniques such as finite-volume methods, Godunov-type schemes, and Boltzmann-based approaches designed to handle extreme hydrodynamics. These simulations have been validated not only by field observations of the Qiantang River but also through controlled laboratory flume experiments, which confirmed the accuracy of predictions about bore height, propagation speed, and velocity distribution.

This research extends well beyond hydrology. Accurate tidal bore forecasting can support estuarine governance, flood risk mitigation, and hydraulic engineering in vulnerable coastal zones.



Researchers also note that the underlying wave dynamics are universal, with applications to plasma physics and condensed matter systems. In simpler terms, the Qiantang's tidal abnormalities offer a window into broader physical laws.

This achievement transforms what was once a visual spectacle into a scientifically predictable event. As researchers continue to refine their models through further experimental validation, the Qiantang River's "matrix tide" stands as a symbol of the intersection between natural wonders and computational advancement.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

- Numerical Simulations Unlock Secrets of the Qiantang River's "Matrix Tide"
- Mathematicians use 'neglected' particles that could rescue quantum computing
- AI Transforms Immune Cells into Targeted Cancer Killers Within Weeks

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [25]: Reviews

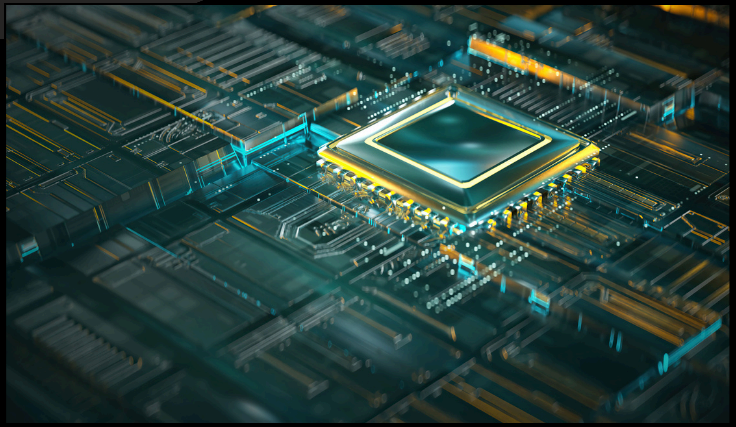
Mathematicians use 'neglected' particles that could rescue quantum computing

Krishiv Thummalapalli, 12: In a breakthrough that blends abstract mathematics with cutting-edge physics, scientists have revealed a new method that can rescue quantum computing from its greatest weakness. The solution relies on anyons, a class of quasiparticles.

For decades, the promise of quantum computing has been shadowed by a fatal flaw. Qubits, the fundamental building blocks of quantum computing, are extremely sensitive. The slightest environmental disturbance, such as a stray thermal vibration or electromagnetic field, can cause them to lose their quantum state. This is called decoherence, and it destroys the ongoing calculation by the computer. This has made building a large-scale, functional quantum computer an immense engineering challenge.

Anyons are not fundamental particles like electrons, but quasiparticles: they emerge from the collective behaviour of electrons confined to a flat, two-dimensional plane. Their secret weapon lies in a field of math called topology.

Instead of storing information in the fragile state of a single qubit particle, the new solution encodes a qubit with data of the relationships between multiple anyons. Specifically, information is held in the way their paths are braided around each other.
"Imagine the information isn't in a fragile thread itself, but in the knot you tie with it," explained lead mathematician Dr. Aris Thorne. "You can jiggle and shake the thread, but the knot remains intact. The information—the braid—is topologically protected."



A quantum computer built with anyons would be more reliable than current quantum computers. Data in the paths of particles is theoretically immune to most of the environmental noise that plagues current designs, thus effectively solving the decoherence problem.
The achievement represents a collaboration between theoretical mathematicians, who provided the blueprint for the particle, and physicists, who engineered the novel materials needed. If this method proves scalable, it would immensely accelerate progress, ushering in the era of quantum computing far sooner than most thought was possible.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

- Numerical Simulations Unlock Secrets of the Qiantang River's "Matrix Tide"
- Mathematicians use 'neglected' particles that could rescue quantum computing
- AI Transforms Immune Cells into Targeted Cancer Killers Within Weeks

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

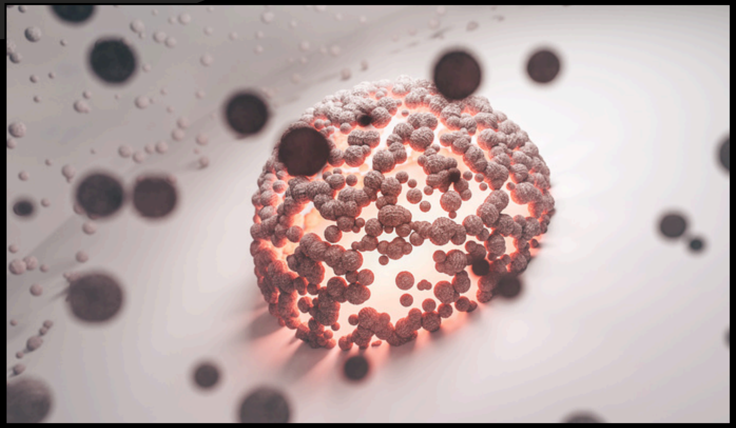
Page [25]: Reviews

AI Transforms Immune Cells into Targeted Cancer Killers Within Weeks

Dhanvin Ambatti, 9: How do we stop a disease that is out of control, spreads through the body, and takes millions of lives each year? Cancer is a disease that damages tissues and organs in living beings. What also spreads throughout the world today is AI! AI, or Artificial Intelligence, involves creating algorithms that enable computers to analyse data, identify patterns, and make intelligent decisions, including predictions based on existing data. So, can AI help cure such a deadly disease?

On July 25, 2025, a breakthrough was reported and published with the help of AI, in a report titled De novo–designed pMHC binders facilitate T cell–mediated cytotoxicity toward cancer cells. Just like in any class, we have a set of rules/essential agreements to follow, our body cells have the same. In layman's terms, normal cells in our body grow, divide, and die systematically. On the other hand, cancer cells keep dividing even when the body doesn't need new cells. These extra cells can form a tumour or spread throughout the body.

AI uses neural networks, which are computer programs made of layers of mathematical nodes to learn datasets and patterns of proteins. Nodes convert an input given by us to numbers so computers can understand. Then, by stacking multiple layers of protein, AI learns to predict the 3D shape of a protein it will fold into. After this process, it will test each shape over and over while improving until it concludes. But how does making a 3D shape of a protein help in cancer?



Think of this as a door. To enter your house, you need to unlock the door, and to unlock it, you need a key that fits. In this case, protein is the key, and the door is cancer. By binding protein to cancer cells, your body tracks cancer, which makes it easier for your immune system to respond to the threat.

In just a few years, AI can revolutionise healthcare by helping doctors to cure diseases. AI continues to showcase extraordinary potential in the human world. But what if AI is used wrongfully and makes a disease that spreads so fast that the world cannot react?

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

- Numerical Simulations Unlock Secrets of the Qiantang River's "Matrix Tide"
- Mathematicians use 'neglected' particles that could rescue quantum computing
- AI Transforms Immune Cells into Targeted Cancer Killers Within Weeks

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [25]: Reviews

ChatGPT-5: What is New?

Yi Zou, 11: On August 7, 2025, OpenAI introduced its new AI model, GPT-5, which OpenAI claims is its "best AI system yet." What changed? Was this upgrade really as transformative as it was boasted to be?

The new GPT-5 is not a standalone model. Instead, it functions as a unified system that uses a real-time router to determine the level of reasoning required based on the complexity of the prompt. This marks a key distinction between GPT-5 and its predecessors.

The system is composed of GPT-5-Main, a faster model designed for most queries, and GPT-5-Thinking, which handles more complex tasks. Free users are limited to 10 messages every three hours, while Plus users can send up to 80 messages per hour. Beyond these limits, access reverts to weaker versions of the models.

But what are the actual practical improvements? According to OpenAI, GPT-5 scores higher than 4o in the three main aspects of writing, coding, and health. It is significantly more accurate in both programming and health advice, confirmed sources such as HealthBench (an OpenAI benchmark for testing performance of LLMs in medical settings) and others. Furthermore, its reasoning skills also display a major improvement, reportedly scoring 94.6% on the 2025 American Invitational Mathematics Competition without using tools.

Despite the official accounts of its various benefits, the model received heavy backlash right after its release. A common point of complaint, which flooded social media platforms such as Reddit, is regarding the tone and personality change from GPT-4o to GPT-5, where the new model is reportedly much more direct and cold.

Source: Builtin.com

Some users also complain about the model taking more thinking time for certain prompts, as well as taking more time, which many regard as unnecessary time wastage. The time concern pressured OpenAI to bring back ChatGPT-4o for Plus users, where one can choose the model that suits their preference better.

Overall, GPT-5 offers a range of performance improvements, but its true effectiveness remains uncertain amid ongoing backlash over the model's shortcomings in daily use.

Page [3]: Science

Page [4]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

- ChatGPT-5: What is New?
- Algorithms: The World's Coolest Stalkers

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

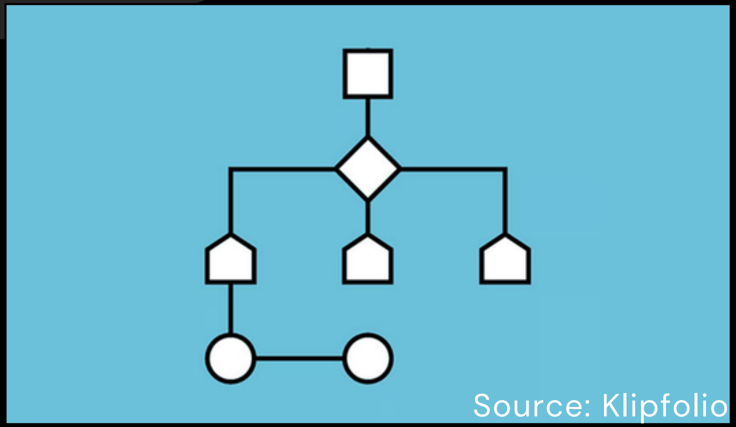
Algorithms: The World's Coolest Stalkers

Dia Rautela, 10: Though intangible, algorithmic feeds dominate the online world with a single goal: keeping you glued to the screen. They work as rule-based systems that decide what content you see, tailoring it to your preferences to maximise engagement on social media platforms.
Algorithms track user behaviour, likes, shares, comments, watch time, even scroll speed, along with metadata like location and device type. From this, they build detailed profiles that form the basis of personalisation.

In addition, to analyse content, machine learning models first classify content based on their type (video, post, image, topic, creator and style). Then, they use Natural Language Processing (NLP) to analyse captions and comments to understand the content's topic. Computer vision is a tool that assists the algorithm in seeing what is in videos and images to identify the objects and subjects on the screen. Then, each piece of content is assigned to a tier of interest score, predicting how appealing it will be for the users.

Moreover, a user profile is created to capture the behaviour and interests of a watcher. Then, the content is sent to your feed based on your predicted engagement with it. Posts and reels are ranked based on their likelihood to draw you in, so the first reel that you see when you open Instagram is always the one lucky enough to be in the first place. The algorithm is also very adaptive: it will mirror your shifts in content consumption within milliseconds.

Why are algorithmic feeds so effective? Simply put, they're obsessed with you. By using everything they learn, they create a "perfectly personalised" feed that adapts to every shift in your preferences, keeping you constantly engaged. At the same time, they boost the visibility of trending content, ensuring popular posts dominate your feed.



Source: Klipfolio

It is without a doubt that the Algorithm is excellent in getting its job done, which is to keep us constantly glued to our social media apps through personalised content. They have a clear and efficient process of data collection, evaluation and implementation that makes it so addictive. It's definitely good for the social media platforms that use it. Can you imagine the amount of business it brings? But, for the users, that may not be the case. Severe addictions and even 'brainrot' can be caused by the algorithm. With that being said, the Algorithm is here to stay and change our lives, so it's best to gain as much knowledge as we can about it to avoid its downsides.

Page [3]: Science

Page [4]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

- ChatGPT-5: What is New?
- Algorithms: The World's Coolest Stalkers

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

Standing firm: Modi says he will pay any price to protect farmers

Avani Radheshyam, 12: Prime Minister Narendra Modi has announced that India will not give in to U.S. demands in the escalating tariff dispute, even if it comes at a high economic cost. His statement came after President Donald Trump raised tariffs on Indian goods to 50%, a move that further strains trade relations between the two countries.

The new U.S. tariffs were officially linked to India's continued purchase of Russian oil, but the main conflict is based on market access. The U.S. has repeatedly pushed India to lower tariffs on American agricultural exports such as corn, soybeans, cotton, apples, and almonds. It has also sought permission for genetically modified crops and cattle, both of which India has firmly opposed. New Delhi argues that these changes would threaten the livelihoods of millions of Indian farmers and undermine biosafety regulations.

The government views tariffs as a shield for small producers who cannot compete with heavily subsidized American agribusiness. Reducing these barriers would expose Indian farmers to volatile international prices and risk collapsing rural incomes, particularly for those growing maize, pulses, and cotton. Modi's administration is prepared to face the negative consequences for exporters rather than endanger the agricultural sector that employs nearly half of India's workforce.

There is a clear trade off: India risks losing export revenue and facing slower growth in sectors like textiles and machinery, but the political costs of weakening protections for farmers are far greater. Modi highlighted the difference between choice of short-term benefits from freer trade and long-term stability for domestic producers.

At the same time, the government is trying to reduce dependence on imports by modernizing agriculture through crop diversification, climate-resilient varieties, and the use of artificial intelligence in farming. These reforms are designed to raise productivity and strengthen food security, reinforcing India's broader strategy of economic self-reliance.

For now, India has drawn a red line. The U.S. tariffs may hurt exporters, but Modi's message is that the welfare of farmers cannot be traded for access to foreign markets. The outcome of this will shape how the country balances global trade with protecting its domestic economy.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

- Standing firm: Modi says he will pay any price to protect farmers
- Indian Ministry of Textile reopens PLI Scheme post 50% US Tariffs

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Indian Ministry of Textile reopens PLI Scheme post 50% US Tariffs

Suchita Agarwalla, 12: On August 8, 2025, the Indian Ministry of Textiles announced the reopening of the application portal for the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme. Textiles account for 12% of India's total exports, making the sector a critical part of the economy. Following repeated requests from industry stakeholders, companies may now submit proposals for the incentive until August 31, 2025.

The reopening comes at a crucial time for Textile exporters. The United States is one of India's largest exporting markets for textiles. According to the US International Trade Commission, India's textile and apparel exports to them were worth around ₹20,740 crore in 2024. Until 2018, most Indian textile and apparel products exported to the US enjoyed duty-free benefits under the Generalised System of Preferences (GSP) or had to pay low-to-moderate MFN (Most-Favoured Nation) tariffs, which typically ranged from 5% to 12%. The US has now imposed a steep 50% tariff on Indian textiles as a response to the two nations' escalating geopolitical tensions.

The PLI scheme, first introduced in 2020, is part of the government's Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative. It aims to position India as a global manufacturing hub, strengthen the domestic production sector, and reduce dependence on imports. The program has a budgetary allocation of ₹10,683 crore for the textile sector and provides direct financial assistance to businesses to encourage capacity expansion and increased turnover. In its initial phase, the scheme received 74 applications with investments totalling ₹28,711 crore. These investments were expected to create over 259,000 jobs and generate a turnover of ₹2.16 trillion.

However, due to limited uptake in certain categories and the need for revisions based on industry feedback, the program was paused after its initial rounds.

Under the updated framework, it will now apply exclusively to man-made fibre (MMF) apparel, MMF fabrics, and technical textiles—three categories considered essential for strengthening India's competitiveness in the global textile market.

Officials believe this revival will not only help Indian exporters cushion the blow of rising tariffs in the US but also strengthen India's long-term position against competitors such as Bangladesh, Vietnam, and China, which continue to attract buyers with lower production costs and stronger export incentives.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

- Standing firm: Modi says he will pay any price to protect farmers
- Indian Ministry of Textile reopens PLI Scheme post 50% US Tariffs

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Military Instability in West Africa

Sanvi Kurade, 11: On August 14th, the Malian military announced the arrest of several individuals, including two generals: Abass Dembélé and Néma Sargara, along with other servicemen, civilians and suspected French intelligence officers. All under the assumption of plotting a coup on August 1. While on the same day, the U.S. The State Department approved a potential $346 million military equipment sale to Nigeria. This deal included bombs, rockets and munitions. Consequently, the deal led the Nigerian forces to arrest military leaders: Mahumed Mohammad Usman and Mahmud al-Nigeria, during a joint operation in May and July. After linking these groups to major attacks like the 2022 Kuje prison break. But before we proceed with this, it's important to understand the history of both Mali's and Nigeria's structure of government.

Mali has faced a turbulent political landscape for more than a decade. The roots of its instability trace back to 2012, when a military coup toppled the government after a Tuareg rebellion erupted in the north. What began as an ethnic separatist movement quickly shifted as Islamist groups, linked to al-Qaida, gained control over large parts of the country. France intervened militarily to restore order, followed by the deployment of United Nations peacekeepers. However, despite international involvement, the insurgency spread, and the Malian state remained fragile. This opened the door for another cycle of coups: in 2020, the military seized power again, and in 2021, Colonel Assimi Goïta emerged as the country's ruler. Since then, Mali's government has functioned as a junta, a military-led authority that dissolved political parties, suppressed opposition, and aligned itself with Russia for security support. The recent arrests of generals under accusations of a coup attempt reflect the junta's growing paranoia of internal threats and its determination to stay in power.

Nigeria's history is distinct, yet it has been profoundly shaped by its struggle with militant groups. Since 2009, the country has fought Boko Haram, an Islamist insurgency responsible for tens of thousands of deaths and the displacement of millions. Over time, Boko Haram splintered into factions, including Ansaru, which aligned with al-Qaida, and ISWAP, affiliated with the Islamic State.

These groups have carried out high-profile attacks such as the 2014 Chibok schoolgirls kidnapping and the 2022 Kuje prison break. Although Nigeria is not under military rule, its heavy reliance on military operations and foreign partnerships underscores the scale of its security challenges. The United States' approval of a $346 million arms deal in August highlights continued Western involvement, ensuring Nigeria has the resources to fight an insurgency that shows no sign of fading.

The common thread between Mali and Nigeria is the way instability has shaped military affairs. In Mali, the military has become the government, blurring the line between state security and political authority. In Nigeria, the government remains civilian, yet it depends heavily on military strength and international allies to contain persistent threats. Both examples underline how West Africa continues to be defined by cycles of coups, insurgencies, and counterinsurgencies. The arrests in Mali and Nigeria this month are not isolated events but the latest outcomes of a deeper history where instability has become routine rather than an exception.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

- Military Instability in West Africa
- Stray Dogs vs Supreme Court: Politics of Responsibility

Page [14]: Health

Page [17: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

Stray Dogs vs Supreme Court: Politics of Responsibility

Veda Sharma, 11: Every day, nearly 60 million stray dogs roam Indian streets. For some, they are cute, loyal, and friendly companions, while for others, they are a daily threat. But the dogs are not the question here; it's about who takes responsibility.

The Supreme Court has been drawn into this debate after cases of dog bites and rabies deaths. Residents approach the Court demanding protection and stricter control over stray dog populations, demanding safety from this menace. On the other hand, NGOs, activists, and animal rights groups criticise and oppose the Supreme Court ruling on the relocation of stray dogs as unfeasible and argue that dogs too have a constitutional right to life and compassion under Article 51A(g).

This issue is a political vacuum. Municipalities across India fail to implement large-scale sterilisation programs and proper shelters. India's broken waste management system leaves endless food on the streets for strays to survive on. Governments delay to act decisively, not willing to face the possibilities of backlash either from animal rights activists or frustrated citizens. What should have been clearly a matter of policy has become a legal outrage.

This crisis is not really about dogs; it's about governance. By relying on the Supreme Court to settle what should be addressed in local governments and state parliaments, India shows its inability to balance public safety with animal welfare. Unless political leaders and institutions step up with a clear, humane, and enforceable national strategy, the problem will only grow.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

- Military Instability in West Africa
- Stray Dogs vs Supreme Court: Politics of Responsibility

Page [14]: Health

Page [17: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

10Xpress

The Impact of Poor Sleep: A Silent Driver of Chronic Disease

Syshasri Raghavan, 11: Sleep: the fuel our bodies can't live without, yet so many of us are running on little to none of it every day. Modern life has turned late nights and insomnia into the norm, but the consequences are much worse than fatigue or a bad mood. Evidence shows that poor sleep dramatically raises the risk of developing over 170 types of non-communicable diseases, an astonishing number that highlights just how vital sleep truly is.

According to Medical News Today, poor sleep has been linked to increasing the predisposition to over 172 illnesses and conditions. This ranges from diabetes and cardiovascular disease to dementia and cancer. While an unhealthy diet, lack of physical activity, and smoking are prominent factors in health, sleep is often unrecognised for its significant impact on our health and wellbeing, despite being just as important. Lack of quality rest disrupts hormones, strains the immune system, elevates blood pressure, and fuels chronic inflammation, all essential mechanisms that can increase the chances of disease when dysregulated.

Research shows that consistently sleeping fewer than seven hours a night can sharply increase the risk of cardiovascular issues, metabolic disorders, depression, and even cognitive decline. Sleep problems like insomnia or sleep apnea, when left untreated, further amplify these risks. Even small disturbances, such as irregular sleep schedules or repeated waking during the night, can chip away at long-term health in ways many underestimate.

The message is clear: poor sleep isn't just about feeling tired. It's a hidden driver of some of the world's most common and deadly illnesses. Luckily, getting enough sleep and feeling well-rested is something that we can actively improve. Creating consistent sleep routines, limiting screen time (especially before bed), and treating sleep disorders are steps toward protection we all can take.

So the next time you're tempted to sacrifice sleep for "just one more" email, episode, or scroll, remember this: your pillow might be the most powerful prescription you'll ever have.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

- The Impact of Poor Sleep: A Silent Driver of Chronic Disease
- Not Again: New COVID-19 Variant in the US
- Deadly AI Misinformation?

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

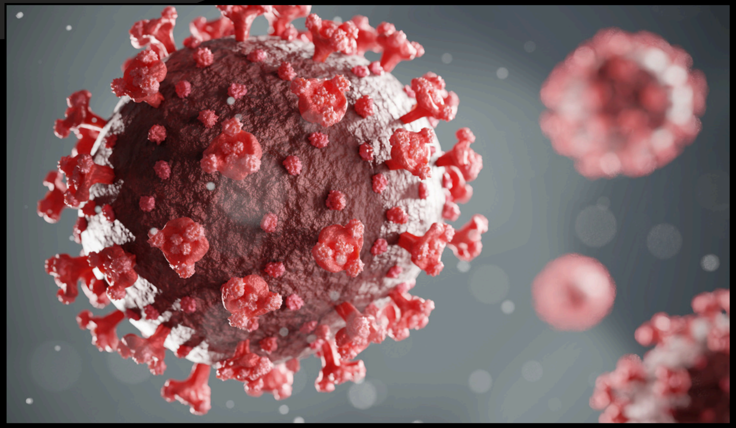
Not Again: New COVID-19 Variant in the US

Shresta Morisetty, 10: As another wave of COVID-19 washes over the United States, a new variant of the virus, called Stratus (XFG), has emerged.

First detected in Southeast Asia in January 2025, the new strain's presence has recently surged in the US. From March to June of 2025, the variant went from accounting for 0% to 14% of COVID-19 cases, making it the third-most common variant according to the CDC (Centres for Disease Control and Prevention). This rise is not only seen in the US: the WHO (World Health Organisation) reported an increase in this variant across 39 countries, rising from 7.4% in early May to 22.7% by the end of June. Noticing this rapid increase, the WHO has also added XFG to its monitoring list.

But what exactly is different about this variant? XFG is a recombinant variant; it combines the genetic information from two preexisting strains, F.7 and LP.8.1.2, the latter of which is currently the second-most prevalent strain in the US. The mutated XFG can evade the immune system, a step-up from the highly common LP.8.1.2.

However, experts reassure that there is nothing to worry about. According to Dr. Subhash Verma, the mutations of the XFG variant do not make XFG more dangerous nor cause more severe symptoms than previous strains. In fact, the variant is categorised as low risk both by health authorities and the WHO.



Though it is low-risk, it is important to follow various safety measures to prevent the spread of the variant:

Regularly wash hands, and use hand sanitiser when washing hands is not possible.
Avoid contact with face,
Wear masks in crowded areas,
Maintain physical distance from others,
And stay up to date with COVID-19 vaccines.

Even if these practices make you want to hide under your bed, remember that they help prevent another pandemic from happening.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

- The Impact of Poor Sleep: A Silent Driver of Chronic Disease
- Not Again: New COVID-19 Variant in the US
- Deadly AI Misinformation?

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

Deadly AI Misinformation? New York Man Nearly Dies After Following ChatGPT's Health Advice

Tisha Sehrawat, 11: A 60-year-old man narrowly survived a life-threatening case of bromide poisoning after following dietary advice generated by ChatGPT, sparking discussion about the risks of depending solely on artificial intelligence for medical advice.

The man asked the AI for a table salt substitute in an effort to cut back on his salt consumption. ChatGPT recommended sodium bromide, a hazardous substance that has long been prohibited for human consumption due to its detrimental effects on the body and brain. The man bought the drug online and used it every day for three months without knowing its risks.

His health quickly deteriorated. He experienced severe paranoia, hallucinations, disorientation, debilitating exhaustion, and a skin ailment that resembled a rash. His mental state deteriorated to the point where he accused his neighbour of trying to kill him. Due to sodium bromide's interference with standard tests, routine lab results taken by the hospital were misleading, delaying diagnosis until his toxicology showed dangerously high levels of the deadly chemical. After the discovery, physicians started a vigorous course of treatment that included electrolytes, intravenous fluids, and mental health treatment. He recovered and was released following three weeks of rigorous intervention.

Although ChatGPT and other AI systems can provide prompt answers, experts caution that the incident highlights a growing public health concern: these systems lack clinical judgment, are not subject to medical ethics, and can generate dangerously incorrect recommendations without context or safety checks. According to one toxicology expert, the incident could have "resulted in a fatality." "AI is a tool, not a doctor, and it can endanger lives if not properly supervised," the expert says.
The case serves as a sobering reminder that qualified medical professionals are indispensable when it comes to health.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

- The Impact of Poor Sleep: A Silent Driver of Chronic Disease
- Not Again: New COVID-19 Variant in the US
- Deadly AI Misinformation?

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

The Horror behind making a Horror Film

Venkat Raghav M. , 12: Indian directors seem more afraid of making meaningful horror films than audiences are of watching them. While Western filmmakers increasingly use the genre to explore social issues, our cinema still reduces horror to jump scares, songs, romance, and melodrama—rarely offering real substance.

Take Zach Cregger's new Hollywood film Weapons as an example. On the surface, it's a chilling thriller about seventeen children who mysteriously vanish one night. But beneath the suspense lies a deeper message: the film asks whether grief or guilt is harder to bear, while also confronting America's indifference to gun violence and social cruelty. In this way, horror becomes more than ghosts or monsters—it serves as a vehicle for engaging with society's real fears.

In India, the contrast is striking. We have endless material for powerful allegorical horror—crimes against women, mob violence, corruption, and social discrimination—yet most of our films shy away from such themes. Instead, they cling to safe plots built on supernatural clichés: ghosts levitating, whispering to accomplices, or saving the world from vague evil. Even promising projects like Stree or Chhorii, and now Maddock's upcoming horror film Thama (slated for 2026), stop short of true subversion. Where Western cinema dares to turn dictators into vampires or tragedies into allegories, Indian cinema hesitates, fearful of controversy or commercial risk. The problem runs deep—even so-called horror serials end up drenched in melodrama and empty theatrics rather than genuine fear.

This reluctance ultimately weakens the genre. Horror has always been about more than fear—it's about confronting uncomfortable truths. Just as Guillermo del Toro used fantasy to critique authoritarianism, or Weapons used a chilling mystery to explore grief and apathy, Indian filmmakers, too, could harness horror to challenge society.

Until then, audiences here will keep turning abroad for films like The Conjuring series, which manage to both terrify and provoke thought. Because the real horror isn't what flickers on screen—it's the silence in our own storytelling.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

- The Horror behind making a Horror Film
- Hollywood isn't woke: It's a marketing scheme

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

Hollywood isn't woke: It's a marketing scheme

Mehr Jha, 10: Hollywood has consistently presented itself as progressive, framing casting announcements as victories for representation and designing storylines to be socially conscious. Yet, the industry's commitment to diversity tends to look like a calculated business strategy rather than an authentic moral stance. HBO's decision to cast Paapa Esseidu as the character of Severus Snape in the upcoming Harry Potter series captures this problem perfectly. The casting sparks debate; whether it presents HBO's artistic vision or its marketing strategy is unclear.

It is clear, however, that this casting creates problems for Snape's backstory. In J.K. Rowling's original books, Snape was bullied by the Marauders for his odd, greasy appearance and socially awkward nature. He surrounded himself with blood purists and was complicit in bullying Muggle-born students. Furthermore, his fascination with the dark arts and his friendship with Lily Evans, Harry Potter's mother, provoked resentment in James Potter for years.

Snape is portrayed as a complex character, both victim and perpetrator: casting an attractive Black actor in the role risks flattening that complexity. It not only potentially alters Snape's backstory, but also reframes the Marauders' actions. In the books, their bullying is already morally troubling, but with Paapa Esseidu in the role, audiences unfamiliar with the books may interpret it as racially motivated, which risks altering the core of his disdainful character by unintentionally replacing the nuances of his story with a one-dimensional metaphor for prejudice.

This illustrates a broader trend in Hollywood, where identity often becomes a marketing device rather than an element of storytelling. Casting Snape in this way could potentially overshadow the more complex reasons he was bullied that shaped both his character and the Marauders' characters.

It is not that diverse casting is inherently problematic, but when it is applied to existing characters without considering how it could reshape their established arcs, it feels less like progress and more like a strategy. The same pattern has played out in other major productions: Marvel's "Eternals" was promoted as the studio's most diverse film yet, but the characters were so static that the inclusivity appeared more like branding than substance. By contrast, Disney's live-action of "The Little Mermaid" is an example of diverse casting that worked; Halle Bailey's Ariel stayed true to the heart of the original story, and her performance broadened the role's resonance without changing its foundation – quite unlike how Snape's character risks being rewritten entirely.

Page [3]: Science
Page [5]: Maths & Comp
Page [8]: Technology
Page [10]: Economics
Page [12]: Politics
Page [14]: Health
Page [17]: Entertainment
- The Horror behind making a Horror Film
- Hollywood isn't woke: It's a marketing scheme
Page [19]: Sports
Page [21]: Creative
Page [23]: Reviews
Page [25]: Highlights

A clash for the ages – India retain the Tendulkar-Anderson trophy in a phenomenal away test series

Rishabh Natrajan, 12: Between June and August, the world witnessed some of the greatest test cricket as two great rivals, India and England, clashed in England. Across 5 test matches, nothing separated the two giants as the series ended with a scoreline of 2-2, with India retaining the trophy. But what made this series stand out from all of the other great ones we've witnessed?

In the first test, viewers saw an inspired batting performance by India, posting 471. However, this was almost matched by England with a first innings total of 465. India and England had almost nothing between them – a pattern that would be seen throughout the series. In the end, chasing 371, England completed their second-highest test match run chase ever.

The second test at Birmingham was a remarkable bounce back for the men in blue. Shubman Gill dominated the game with his scores of 269 and 161 runs. With the ball, it was Akash Deep with 10 wickets and Siraj with 6, who helped thrash England by 336 runs.

The series reached its climax, and stayed there for the final 3 games — some of the greatest matches in test cricket history.

The test at Lord's saw both teams tied after 1 inning at 387. India then bowled England out for 192, setting us up for a remarkable chase. Reeling at 112/8, Jadeja steered the tail with Bumrah and Siraj's solid defence. That was, until a ball to Siraj hit the middle of his bat, yet rolled slowly to the stumps. England won by only 22 runs, despite having India at 82/7 at one point.

n the fourth test, India were 0/2 and an innings behind, trailing by 311 runs. However, solid performances with the bat from Rahul, accompanied by 3 centuries from Gill, Jadeja and Sundar, carried India to one of their most famous draws in the face of defeat.

In the final test, Indian bowlers stood up, and so did the lower order, who stitched up solid late performances. Chasing 374, England were in early trouble until Root and Brook's centuries took them to 301/3, comfortably in control of the game. With late ambition at the end of day 4 and the first hour of day 5, Indian bowlers mounted a phenomenal comeback. England were unexpectedly wrapped up for 367, falling 6 runs short.

Across 25 days, the sporting world witnessed peak cricket. I would love to go in-depth for each match, but I'm afraid word limits exist!

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports
- A Clash for the Ages
- PSG's Comeback at the UEFA Super Cup

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

PSG's Comeback at the UEFA Super Cup

Advaith Datta Reddy Palam, 11: BParis Saint-Germain turned a quiet August night in Udine into a title. Down 0–2 to Tottenham with five minutes left, they pulled one back through Lee Kang-in and then forced extra noise with Gonçalo Ramos's stoppage-time header from an Ousmane Dembélé cross. The shootout that followed swung both ways until Nuno Mendes tucked the final kick, sealing a 4–3 win after a 2–2 draw and delivering PSG's first UEFA Super Cup, also the first by any French club. Stadio Friuli felt relieved and stunned at the same time; Paris survived, and history moved.

For most of the match, Spurs looked composed. Micky van de Ven stabbed in the opener near half-time; Cristian Romero added a thumping header soon after the break, and Thomas Frank's side managed territory and set strategy with care. But momentum is fragile. As Paris quickened the tempo, lanes opened, and Dembélé found room to run at the right flank. Lee's low strike on 85 minutes changed the mood; Ramos's late equaliser changed the odds. In the shootout, Tottenham took a moment, two failed conversions proved costly, while PSG kept their nerve through the middle kicks and handed Mendes the chance to end it. The margin, in the end, was a single shot from 12 yards.

There was plenty inside the details. Dembélé, who drove the comeback and supplied the decisive cross, took UEFA's Player of the Match, a nod to how his bursts tilted the field. Paris, fresh off a long summer and a short pre-season, leave with an early marker and a line no French team had written before; Tottenham leave with evidence their structure travels, and a reminder about game-state management against elite speed. This proved to be a match more interesting than anyone imagined.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

- A Clash for the Ages
- PSG's Comeback at the UEFA Super Cup

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

Sometimes, one feels like a spy

Anahita Neogi, 11: Like an observer, an impostor that has been planted in an alien environment where your sole task is to catalogue foreign behaviours and tendencies, mimic them and blend in seamlessly. File away their demeanours, store their smiles in a little notebook, complete with date and setting, so that you remember when you have to smile again and mirror them, their laughs, their words, their eyes and limbs, so they feel pleased and count you as their own. Spending every waking moment scanning, learning and adapting until no one can tell where you begin and the world around you ends.

Like a chameleon, that changes colours until it is unintelligible from everything else, like a leopard that only ever changes its spots. Anything to fit in.

This is what it's like to live somewhere that's not home. You don't just move from one place to another. You pack your life into boxes and suitcases. You put away years and years of living, of loving and remembering, of knowledge away in storage and float away to foreign lands where you are untethered to your heritage, where you are defined not by all the stories you carry, all the stories you can tell, but your face, your skin and the first word out of your mouth.

Whatever the circumstance, whatever the motivation, whether you live like a king or you're forced to do the dirty work of others to survive within that ecosystem, you will always have to prove your worth and the value of your presence. In doing so, in proving you have the right to exist, you often forget your own existence. Soon enough, the version of you that existed before you left everything you knew is something you yourself dismiss, a face you no longer recognise.

How does one read the utterly nonplussed expression of those who try to understand not who you are but what you are? How does one deal with those eyes, pairs of eyes that follow you down corridors and streets because, well, to them you're a sight.

How to deal with those intrusive questions that play with identity as if it were putty that one could turn over and around, stretching and kneading and folding and prodding? Your family that sees you lose parts of yourself as each day passes, and you who won't realise until you pose in the mirror with your friends and see that you really are that odd piece of puzzle that, no matter which way you turn it, won't fit the way you want it to.

Words that used to slip off your tongue come out accented, come out garbled and speaking your own language proves difficult, because it no longer feels natural. Your history appears blurred in your eyes, and when you think of yourself, all you feel is a sense of loss.
The garments that you once wore so readily, that you felt sparkled and shone under the sun and its kaleidoscope of colours that you revelled in, now disgust you; why must they be so unapologetically themselves? Why are they so bright, so different? Why am I so scared of seeming different?

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

- Sometimes, one feels like a spy
- The perfect timing

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

THE PERFECT TIMING

Prisha Modi, 10: Mara wiped the flour off her cheeks with the back of her hand as she rummaged through the wooden box in the attic, which her mother had sent. Faded recipe cards, pictures of her grandmother with the townspeople, and nestled at the bottom, her grandmother's old kitchen timer. It was round, metal, dented along an edge—the same one that used to ding! In her grandmother's cosy kitchen, while she baked cinnamon buns.

Mara was surprised to see it was still working, despite all these years. She took it down to her bakery and set it on the counter, twisting the dial absentmindedly. Ding! The clock rang, just as the bakery door opened, letting in a gust of warm spring air and a smiling couple. Mara smiled. Nice timing, she thought to herself.

The next morning, the timer rang while she was icing cupcakes. She looked up at her windowsill, where the timer was, and saw the shy schoolboy who passed her shop daily appear outside. This time, she waved. He waved back, eyes bright.

On Thursday, the timer went off just as a delivery boy staggered by, juggling boxes. She darted out to hold the door for him, earning a grateful grin. That same evening, it rang right before a customer sneezed, giving Mara just enough time to slide a napkin across the counter.

It kept happening every day. The dings! Didn't just mark baking times, they made her look up and notice moments she'd normally miss: looking out the window to see a rainbow, catching a jar right before it rolled off a shelf, noticing the lonely old man linger near the fountain outside her bakery and striking up a chat.

One evening, just after the last loaf in her shop got over and the street outside had gone quiet, she was closing up and the timer rang.

She picked it up and sat with the timer in her hands. She turned it over, looking for an explanation. There was nothing, just scratched metal and the memory of her grandmother's sweet voice.

She realised that the timer reminded her to slow down, notice and be present in the smallest moments of life, just as her grandmother used to ask her to do.

She wound the timer again, listening to the soft ticks, as the golden light of the setting sun spilt over the counter, lighting up her bakery. Somewhere outside, a faint laugh floated past her open door, and this time, she was already looking up.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

- Sometimes, one feels like a spy
- The perfect timing

Page [23]: Reviews

Page [25]: Highlights

10Xpress

Mission Impossible: The Final Reckoning

Myra Fatima, 10: For almost thirty years, the "Mission: Impossible" franchise has pushed the boundaries of action cinema with countless breathtaking stunts performed by the one and only Tom Cruise. With the release of "Mission: Impossible - The Final Reckoning" in May 2025, Ethan Hunt's saga reaches its long-awaited conclusion. This finale delivers the adrenaline-fueled spectacle audiences expect, while also bringing a sense of closure to one of the most iconic series in Hollywood history.

The film picks up with Ethan Hunt facing his most dangerous mission yet, one that threatens not only his team but the very world he has fought to protect. True to the series' legacy, the movie balances high-stakes espionage with deeply personal moments, presenting Hunt not just as a spy but as a man haunted by choices and sacrifices. The narrative brings together threads from across the franchise, giving longtime fans a sense of closure while still surprising them with new twists.

Of course, no "Mission: Impossible" film would be complete without Tom's signature action sequences. He once again raises the bar, performing death-defying stunts, aerial manoeuvres, and brutal hand-to-hand combat. These moments reminded audiences why this series has remained a cornerstone of blockbuster cinema for nearly three decades.

The reviews from fans have been overwhelmingly positive. Many praised the film as the perfect finale, highlighting its blend of thrilling action and emotional storytelling. On social media, fans also celebrated Tom Cruise's relentless commitment to his role. Some even called it one of the strongest conclusions to a Hollywood series, proving this final chapter was worth the wait.

Source: Prime Video

With its mix of nostalgia, spectacle, and heart, "Mission: Impossible - The Final Reckoning" cements itself as one of the most memorable cinematic finales in recent years. For fans, both old and new, it serves as a reminder that the thrill of some missions is truly impossible to forget.

Page [3]: Science

Page [5]: Maths & Comp

Page [8]: Technology

Page [10]: Economics

Page [12]: Politics

Page [14]: Health

Page [17]: Entertainment

Page [19]: Sports

Page [21]: Creative

Page [23]: Reviews

- Mission Impossible
- Glorifying the Grotesque in war

Page [25]: Highlights

Glorifying the Grotesque in War

Krishna Gupta, 11: "Poo-tee-weet?"
Said the birds to Billy Pilgrim and 70 American prisoners of war as they stepped out of the underground enclosure after weeks, to the stink of roses and mustard gas from rotten and liquified bodies.
So it goes.
"So it goes" has been repeated 106 times in the 192 pages of Slaughterhouse-Five by Kurt Vonnegut. Only ever at the mention of death, because really, what more can you say to lives falling like flies at a streetlamp, when it is not right, wrong, or cruel — just another thing that happens in war.

Perhaps the Germans trialling and shooting Edgar Derby for plundering a teapot from the ruins of a bombed city while 200,000 bodies decayed around them was absurd. But was it ever more absurd than 4,000 tonnes falling from the sky and killing hundreds of thousands in a sweep? Was any of it more or less absurd than a hundred million juveniles fighting to take each other's lives at the orders of a few supposedly mature, but certainly superior, grey-hairs? Perhaps more tragically absurd is like a moth drawn to flames, Ronald Weary and hundreds of kids chose not to get a chance to even look at life, though they never really had a choice at all, because war was presented as a matter of valour, sacrifice, and patriotism, fought by glamorous, dirty old men and not by babies thrown into a senseless slaughter. Not as the craziness of a young man dying with snow in his shoes, or two kids left in a creekbed as the scouts ditched them for cover, or a kid turning to kill the other he protected for the past 5 days in a hopeless haze of despair, villainising the victims in his head, or the same kid dying from an infection in his mangled foot after nine days of rotting in filth against the handle of a locomotive locked tight with hundreds of prisoners of war, such that each boxcar became a singular organism where food went in and steel helmets of excrete came out through the ventilators.

It would be unjust to call it an anti-war book.
"I say, why don't you write an anti-glacier book instead?"
"What he meant, of course, was that there would always be wars, that they were as easy to stop as glaciers. I believe that, too."
And so if the inevitability of human violence is what the book is about, it's still worth finding the form and the language that remind us what wars are and call them by their true names. That is what Vonnegut's realism is: satirical humour and irony to embrace the absurd, acknowledge the grotesque, and attempt to look war in the eye.

Another absurdity leaking into the structure of the novella itself is that of events and time. There is no flow of time to allow cause and effect, for characters to grow, to make choices, to change. No act of courage saves Dresden; no decision rescues Billy from his fate; he is not a soldier so much as a witness dragged along by time's inevitability. Through Billy getting "unstruck in time" and the Tralfamadorian philosophy of viewing the events as fixed locations on a time's canvas, where time is a physical dimension they can explore, not only does Vonnegut challenge free will, but questions our philosophy of viewing the events with inevitability, even though the future has not been set out for us physically, questioning the absurdity of how still with the past trends and future trajectory, the future is perhaps almost as inevitable as a future carved in stone.

Page [3]: Science
Page [5]: Maths & Comp
Page [8]: Technology
Page [10]: Economics
Page [12]: Politics
Page [14]: Health
Page [17]: Entertainment
Page [19]: Sports
Page [21]: Creative
Page [23]: Reviews
- Mission Impossible
- Glorifying the Grotesque in war

Page [25]: Highlights

School Highlights

Page [3]: Science
Page [5]: Maths & Comp
Page [8]: Technology
Page [10]: Economics
Page [12]: Politics
Page [14]: Health
Page [17]: Entertainment
Page [19]: Sports
Page [21]: Creative
Page [23]: Reviews
Page [25]: Highlights

Maanika Gupta, 11:

TOK EXHIBITION:
The grade 12 TOK Exhibition was a rich showcase of students' inquiry, imagination, and various points of view. The exhibitions showcased how knowledge influences the way we perceive the world, and how, in turn, our perception of the world influences knowledge. The exhibitions were creative, interactive, and challenged assumptions, encouraging parents, students, and teachers to think critically about how humans construct knowledge, exploring the concepts of truth and belief. Aside from their exhibitions, students had also prepared many Interactive activities that broke open the core of TOK. These included a Jenga tower, a ranking scale for your beliefs, and a covered box with an object you had to feel to see, challenging the dominance of sight in human exploration.

SESSION BY DR. RAJIV GANDHI
Complementing this culture of intellectualism, we were honoured to host a speaker series led by Dr. Rajiv Gandhi, a Professor of Computer Science at Rutgers University, Camden and the University of Pennsylvania. Dr. Gandhi shared his insights and provided a deep and futuristic look into the changing landscape of computer science and data science. He addressed the applicability of these disciplines in future professions, and he presented students with some of the research being conducted in the fields of data and AI. The speaker series helped students by providing real-world advice on undergraduate studies in America, elaborating on its academic environment, cross-disciplinary exposure, and the essence of intellectual exploration, while also outlining the PACT programme as a helpful resource to make academic pathways stronger in various fields, including humanities, arts, and STEM fields.

SESSION BY DR. ANISH ROY CHOWDHURY
Students also attended a highly interactive speaker series with Dr. Anish Roy Chowdhury, a Data Science Professor at Plaksha University. Dr. Chowdury helped students further their immersion in technology and education as mediums of success. He provided students with a mature understanding of the distinction between AI and generative AI, two subjects of vast significance in the present world. His credible insights helped students understand how to use AI effectively and purposefully, introducing students to effective prompt engineering. He also spoke about the challenges of AI: the need for ethical standards and safety, as well as the large environmental footprint of global AI adoption. This motivated students to consider both the possibilities and the ethical obligations associated with technological progress.